

situation. He agreed but never took the time to search for the help he needed. Finally, one afternoon the whole situation came to a head when his banker called Allen at his office. "Allen, I need to see you right away. Can you come by my office this afternoon?" he asked.

"Doubtful; this is a busy time," Allen replied as he looked over the contracts on his desk. He had been getting less and less productive as the pressures at home built. It seemed that Sherry was always irritated about one thing or another.

"Allen, I must see you right away," Gary Barnes insisted. "The loan committee has been reviewing your note with the bank and is recommending that we begin foreclosure on your home."

Allen felt a cold wave of fear come over him. "They can't do that," Allen pleaded. "It would ruin me with the firm. We have very strict rules about maintaining a good image in the community."

"Come on over, and let's discuss it, Allen. Maybe there is a way we can find a resolution."

Allen put down the phone, his hand shaking. He knew he had financial problems, but until that moment he hadn't realized how bad they were. He was three months behind on his first mortgage and four months behind on the second. He had been promising the bank that he would catch up on the payments when his midyear bonus came. But that bonus had been just \$6,500, and it had been used to cover draws from the firm for living expenses. Allen's manager had called him in to review his work for the past six months because his productivity had dropped off severely. He knew that the bank's repossessing his home might cost him his job, and he was only a year away from being made a full partner in the firm. His salary and bonuses would increase substantially then. He felt cold fear rising inside as he realized that not only might he not get a partnership, he might even be released from the firm. He had survived one round of layoffs but didn't have any guarantees that he would survive another.